on Tibet—that it was a part of the PRC—that had been agreed upon by the predecessor government, but also to agree to elevate the relationship into a Strategic and Cooperative Partnership for Peace and Prosperity. It is another matter that few questioned how the two neighbours with an unresolved boundary of over 3000 kilometres, and with one partner unwilling to recognize the other's sovereignty and territorial integrity over large tracts of territory, could become strategic partners. It was only some years later that China finally changed its official maps to show Sikkim as a part of India.

China's recognition of Sikkim in 2005 represents an important milestone in India's China diplomacy. It demonstrates that the lessons of the 1950s had been heeded and internalized within the Government of India. On the Sikkim Question, India had resolved the question of sovereignty in a bold manner in the early 1970s when the situation in South Asia was in favour of India, Pakistan was divided and China was internally distracted by the Great Proletarian Cultural Revolution. All that remained after mid-1975 was for China to accept the new reality and with this clear objective in sight, India pursued it for over two decades with the Chinese side, without displaying either haste or anxiety and unmindful of failure. It offers a case study of how results are achieved when systems work.

The institutional memory within the government—because a trained cadre of officers on both the civilian and military sides that had worked on China, was available to offer insight and advice—guided the political leadership into side-stepping a number of traps that the Chinese had laid with the purpose of prolonging Chinese ambiguity on India's sovereign claims over Sikkim state, possibly in perpetuity. At the end, the compulsions of democracy might have led to India compromising on the ideal outcome. This is a pitfall that India